CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Thursday, October 22, 2026

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RE: Vanuatu minister contradicts own government on China police drawdown · PNG parliament resumes Bougainville vote debate · Haines critical, second MP threatened in Perth · NZ inflation slows to 3.7% ahead of expected RBNZ hike · Fortescue warns on China iron ore stalemate

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,793	0.7018	13,747	0.5686
+0.84%	+1.43%	-0.62%	+1.16%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Vanuatu's internal affairs minister says no decision has been taken to reduce China's police presence, days after his own government signed a joint statement with Australia describing the program as "expected to reduce over time."
2. Papua New Guinea's parliament resumed debate on ratifying the 2019 Bougainville referendum result, with the Bougainville affairs minister saying a vote could come at the end of the current session.
3. Australian security agencies plan to review MPs' home and office protection after Helen Haines lost both legs in Monday's attack and a second female MP's Perth office was targeted this week.

TOP STORIES

CHINA-PACIFIC

Vanuatu minister says no decision made to cut Chinese police presence

Vanuatu's Internal Affairs Minister **Andrew Napuat** said his country has made no decision to reduce China's police presence, days after a joint Vanuatu-Australia statement described Beijing's police assistance program as "time-limited and expected to reduce over time." The statement, cleared after a high-level meeting on implementing the Nakamal Agreement, called Australia's own policing arrangements "legally binding" with "no expiry date." A federal government source said Napuat's message was "very different" from one conveyed by another Vanuatu official last week.

per ABC News: "Vanuatu minister contradicts own government on Chinese police drawdown" · also Islands Business

PACIFIC-POLITICS

PNG parliament resumes Bougainville independence debate, vote timing unclear

Debate on Bougainville's political future resumed in Papua New Guinea's parliament, with no fixed timing for a vote on ratifying the 2019 referendum result the government tabled in August. Minister for Bougainville Affairs **Manasseh Makiba** said MPs would be given time to speak and a vote could come at the end of the current session. "The referendum result is a constitutional issue that members will finally decide on," Makiba said.

per ABC Pacific: "PNG parliament resumes debate on Bougainville independence"

AU-POLITICS

Security agencies to review MP home and office protection after Haines attack

Security agencies will review safety precautions for MPs' homes and offices after federal politicians told police and ASIO in briefings they feared widening threats. Options under consideration before parliament returns next week include a new committee on MPs' safety and condolence motions for **Helen Haines**, who lost both legs in Monday's attack. Haines remained in critical condition three days on, as a man was separately charged over an incident at WA MP Hannah Beazley's office.

per Guardian Australia (Josh Butler): "Labor, Coalition and crossbench MPs afraid at home and work after alleged attack on Helen Haines" · also AP · also The New York Times · also The Washington Post

OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

Supacat model in fatal Darwin rollover had flipped before, ABC confirms · ABC News

The six-wheel Supacat transporter that rolled at Mount Bundey on October 5, killing Corporal **Brendan Hannam**, had tipped over in an earlier training incident Defence did not disclose publicly. A four-wheeled UK variant has rolled *more than 30 times*, including once fatally, prompting 2021 UK calls to upgrade roll protection. **Richard Marles** said he asked the defence chief to review "what might be the best vehicle."

AU-POLITICS

Meta sued in Australian class action over alleged social media harm to children · Reuters

A Federal Court claim, the first of its kind in Australia, accuses Meta of building addictive Facebook and Instagram platforms that harm children. The suit lands as parliament considers further social media regulation following debate over youth online safety.

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY

Destiny Church leader says Australia cancelled his visa over online statements · RNZ

Brian Tamaki said he was detained for 12 hours in Brisbane and had his visa cancelled under Section 116 of Australia's Migration Act after flying in for a church conference. He said Border Force documents described his social media statements, including comments about Narendra Modi, as "inflammatory and concerning."

TRADE-ECONOMY

Epic's Fortnite returns to Apple App Store in Australia after antitrust ruling · Reuters

Epic Games' Fortnite returned to Apple's Australian App Store following an antitrust ruling against the tech giant. The decision follows a broader regulatory push against app-store practices that has run in parallel with Canberra's wider tech competition agenda.

AU-DEFENSE

Australia pensions warned to ratchet up cyber defence spending · Bloomberg

Bloomberg reported Australian pension funds are being warned to lift cybersecurity spending, as superannuation pools become higher-value targets. The warning comes as Australian government sites, including the Australian Signals Directorate's cyber.gov.au, were briefly taken offline this week over an unrelated PHP software flaw.

STAT OF THE DAY

3.7%

New Zealand's Q3 annual inflation rate

The slowdown has not eased expectations of a Reserve Bank rate hike next week, a divergence from the RBA's current hold.

Reuters

PACIFIC WIRE

REGIONAL · RNZ PACIFIC

Pacific police chiefs launch PACPOL to tackle transnational crime

Pacific police chiefs formally launched the Pacific Community of Policing, or PACPOL, at the 53rd Pacific Islands Chiefs of Police Conference in Saipan, held October 13-16. Royal Papua New Guinea Constabulary commissioner **David Manning** was named inaugural chair, saying transnational crime, including drug trafficking, human smuggling and firearms trafficking, was the region's biggest policing challenge.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

PNG-Australia Ministerial Forum signs mobility, ICT and ADF recruitment agreements

The 32nd PNG-Australia Ministerial Forum in Port Moresby produced agreements covering the Pacific Mobility Scheme, information and communication technology cooperation, and recruitment of Papua New Guinean citizens into the Australian Defence Force. Australia also agreed to support PNG's health sector on cancer care.

VANUATU · RNZ PACIFIC

Vanuatu warns against 'second republic' claims in Torba province

Prime Minister **Jotham Napat** voiced concern over reports from Gaua Island in Torba province of a group claiming to represent a "second republic" and raising a new flag. The government called any such move unconstitutional and illegal, warning those responsible would face "the full force of the law."

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Australia backs Fiji's maritime security with Bluebottle vessels

Australia will provide Fiji with Bluebottle uncrewed surface vessels to strengthen maritime surveillance and help detect drug trafficking, part of expanded security cooperation between the two countries.

SAMOA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Korea appoints new ambassador to Samoa

South Korea's new ambassador presented credentials in Samoa, reaffirming Seoul's commitment to strengthening bilateral ties, as Pacific states continue to diversify diplomatic partnerships beyond traditional powers.

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC

Fijian deputy PM defends Israel's new status as Pacific Islands Forum partner

Fiji's deputy prime minister **Viliame Gavoka** said "the entire Pacific Islands identify with Israel in ways many would not understand," calling the relationship "biblical and ageless and real." Israel's approval as a PIF development partner, decided at the September leaders meeting, required consensus from all 18 Forum members, including New Zealand.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · REUTERS

New Zealand court strikes down puberty blocker ban

A New Zealand court struck down a government ban on puberty blockers, a ruling with implications for the coalition's health policy agenda ahead of the November 7 election.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Luxon fronts Bay of Plenty residents on toll roads ahead of election

National leader **Christopher Luxon**, touring Pongakawa, Edgecombe and Whakatane with senior candidates, defended toll roads as a way to build infrastructure faster, citing Denmark as a model, as residents pressed him on being "taken for suckers" by two of New Zealand's three toll roads.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · REUTERS

Australia extends KPMG federal contract pause to 2027 after whistleblower review

A review found KPMG Australia mishandled whistleblower claims, prompting the government to extend its pause on awarding the firm new federal contracts until 2027, keeping one of the big four consultancies out of Commonwealth work.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Corruption watchdog's interest 'piqued' by Labor's invite-only grants

A Senate inquiry into Labor's invite-only grants program continues as the National Anti-Corruption Commission's interest is reported to have been "piqued." The scrutiny comes as **Anthony Albanese** was forced to defend a "dirt file" his office sent out about independent MP Helen Haines.

AU-POLITICS · SMH

One Nation MP says his party plans to govern in first speech

In a 20-minute maiden speech, One Nation's **Luke Herdegen** said his party plans to govern, mixing patriotism and Australian spirit with criticism of gender-identity politics and mass immigration, as the party's polling continues to surge.

AU-POLITICS · POLITICO CANBERRA PLAYBOOK

Labor women confronted Meta about threats to Australian MPs before Haines attack

Politico reported that Labor women had raised concerns directly with Meta about escalating threats to Australian MPs before the alleged attack on Helen Haines, adding a social-media accountability dimension to the parliament's pending security response.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

Fortescue warns of possible operations hit as China state buyer talks drag on

Fortescue posted a *6 percent fall* in quarterly iron ore shipments and warned of a possible hit to operations if negotiations with China's state iron ore buyer remain unresolved. The Financial Times separately reported the miner cautioning of a production slowdown without a deal.

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

New Zealand Q3 inflation slows to 3.7% but hike expectations remain

New Zealand's annual inflation slowed to *3.7 percent* in the third quarter, yet markets still expect the Reserve Bank to raise rates next week. Bloomberg separately reported the slowdown comes ahead of an anticipated fourth-quarter fuel price spike.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Westpac axes 140 more roles as Australian bank job cuts intensify

Westpac cut a further 140 roles, adding to a wave of job losses across Australia's major banks that has also seen NAB announce cuts of about *2,500 positions*, roughly six percent of its workforce.

UPCOMING

OCT 26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Marks the formal start of voting ahead of the November 7 poll, with campaign events like Luxon's Bay of Plenty tour intensifying beforehand.

OCT 2026

Reserve Bank of New Zealand cash rate decision

Markets expect a hike despite slowing Q3 inflation, a divergence from the RBA's current hold that will shape the NZD and regional rate settings.

OCT 2026

Australian federal parliament resumes sitting

MPs are expected to consider new security measures and condolence motions for Helen Haines following the attack and subsequent threats against a second MP.

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues, with direct implications for New Zealand's foreign and defence policy settings.

THE WIRE

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

Australia's foreign-investment gatekeeper needs defence expertise

ASPI argues Australia's foreign investment screening body lacks sufficient defence expertise to properly assess national security risk in critical infrastructure, critical minerals and shipbuilding deals, as scrutiny of foreign capital in strategic sectors intensifies.

ASPI STRATEGIST

When thinking about national security, think about local businesses

ASPI argues Australia's strategic assessments overlook the small and medium businesses that keep communities functioning after a disaster or crisis, warning resilience planning needs to extend beyond defence facilities to local economic infrastructure.

AU-POLITICS

ASPI STRATEGIST

Northern Australia: so much economic wealth alongside so much disadvantage

ASPI highlights reporting on the deaths of Indigenous children in Port Hedland alongside northern Australia's resource wealth, arguing the disadvantage undercuts the region's strategic and economic significance to national security planning.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

LOWY INTERPRETER

Cutting migration risks Australia's middle-power clout

The Lowy Interpreter warns that cutting migration would shrink Australia's economy and reduce its international weight, leaving the country lower in the global pecking order at a time it is pressing for greater middle-power influence.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Journalist safety in the Pacific: A Solomon Islands perspective

Devpolicy's **Lloyd Loji**, publisher of the Island Sun News in Honiara, argues mounting legal and digital pressures on Pacific journalists could be addressed by a national safety framework for Solomon Islands before a crisis hits press freedom.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

RUSI

Can AUKUS Submarines Protect Australia's Maritime Trade?

RUSI assesses the strategic rationale for AUKUS submarines against the specific task of securing Australia's seaborne trade. The piece weighs submarine capability against the scale and geography of Australia's trade exposure.

Argument: Examines whether nuclear-powered submarines delivered under AUKUS can meaningfully protect Australia's maritime trade routes.

THE DIPLOMAT

New Zealand's Climate Report Tests Its Pacific Leadership

The Diplomat examines a new New Zealand climate assessment that highlights mounting economic exposure to climate change. It questions whether current policy settings match the scale of risk Wellington identifies for itself and the Pacific.

> **Argument:** Wellington's latest environmental assessment exposes growing economic risks from climate change, testing whether government policy can keep pace with its Pacific leadership claims.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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